Fact-Checking and Editorial Integrity

Olasunkanmi Arowolo

2026

Contents

Lesson Video 1

Transcript 1

Check-in Form: *Not provided*

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Lesson Video

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---------------------------------------------------------------------------
PRODUCTION NOTES
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---------------------------------------------------------------------
Tone: Serious, consequential. Opens with weight and sustains
 gravity throughout. Moments of sharp directness.
Delivery: Speak with deliberate authority. The stakes in this episode
 are real --- let them feel real. Slow the pace on key
 definitions. Acceleration works well in the fact-checking
 technique list.
Music cue: [INTRO MUSIC FADES IN] just before the cold open.
 [MUSIC FADES UNDER] when speaking begins.
 [MUSIC OUT] by the first full sentence of the cold open.
 [OUTRO MUSIC] after the action close.

Notation key:
 [PAUSE] = deliberate 1-2 second pause
 [SLOW DOWN] = reduce pace, let the idea settle
 [ENERGETIC] = lift energy, pick up momentum
 // italics // = emphasis word or phrase
 [beat] = very short micro-pause, less than 1 second
---------------------------------------------------------------------


[PRE-OPEN HOOK - 35 seconds]
[NO MUSIC YET. DRY. CLOSE MIC.]

A news report went out claiming a university had received 200 billion naira
in federal funding. [PAUSE] Students celebrated. Parents shared it.
Administrators made statements. [PAUSE] The next day, a correction appeared.
[beat] The actual figure was 200 million. [SLOW DOWN] Not billion. Million.
[PAUSE] One letter swapped --- B for M. [beat] By the time the correction went
out, the story had already completed three rounds on social media. [PAUSE]
Trust had already been fractured. [beat] And the editor who approved it ---
[beat] had to answer for it. [PAUSE] This episode is about the one thing that
separates a competent editor from a dangerous one.

[INTRO MUSIC - 10 seconds, then fade under]


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SEGMENT ZERO: COLD OPEN
[30-45 seconds]
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Welcome back to Editing and Graphics of Communication in Practice --- the
MCM 202 Audio Series. I'm Ola. [PAUSE] We have walked through the newsroom
workflow. You know who the sub-editor is. You understand that editing goes
beyond grammar. [beat] In this episode, we go further. To the most critical
responsibility any editor carries in any medium. [PAUSE]

Not style. [beat] Not grammar. [PAUSE]

// Truth. // [beat] And what you do when you are not entirely certain you have
it. [PAUSE] This is Episode 4. Let's begin.

[MUSIC OUT]


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SEGMENT ONE: LESSON PROMISE
[20 seconds]
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By the end of this episode, [beat] you will be able to explain the principles of accuracy in editing. You will be able to apply fact-checking techniques to identify unreliable claims in news copy. And you will be able to identify and remove bias and ambiguity from news writing --- the kind that grammar checks will never catch.

SEGMENT TWO: CORE TEACHING --- PART 1
"Advanced Editing: Moving Beyond Grammar to Truth" [4-5 minutes]

Let me put a question to you. [PAUSE] Is a grammatically correct sentence always a // good // sentence? [beat] Think about it honestly. [PAUSE]

You can have a sentence where every word is spelled correctly, every verb agrees with its subject, every comma sits in the right place. [beat] And the sentence can still be // dangerous //. [PAUSE] Because it might be factually wrong. It might be biased. It might be ambiguous --- meaning two entirely different things depending on who reads it. [PAUSE]

// This is what advanced editing addresses. // [SLOW DOWN]

Advanced editing is the point where you stop correcting and start // deciding //. You are not just asking: is this sentence grammatically correct? You are asking: is this // true //? Is this // clear // for this specific audience? Is this // fair // to everyone involved? Does it expose the organization to legal or ethical risk? What does this frame suggest about the subject --- and is that the // right // frame for this context? [PAUSE]

These are editorial decisions. Not editorial corrections. And there is a real difference. [ENERGETIC] Corrections fix what is broken. Decisions shape what is // communicated //. [PAUSE]

The principles of accuracy rest on this foundation: every fact must be correct. Names spelled and verified correctly. Dates confirmed. Figures checked. Locations accurate. And all of it must be // verifiable // --- meaning, if someone challenges what you published, you can point immediately to a credible, named source. [PAUSE]

[SLOW DOWN] A single inaccurate figure can destroy a publication's credibility. Not weaken it. // Destroy // it. [PAUSE]

Here is a direct example. A story reads: "The Federal Government allocates 3 million naira to the education sector." [beat] Does that figure look correct? [PAUSE] Now the story is revised: "The Federal Government allocates 3 billion naira to the education sector." [beat] One letter. M and B. [PAUSE]

The scale of the figure has just shifted by a factor of one thousand. [beat] And to a non-specialist reader, both sentences look normal. Both are grammatically perfect. Both could slip past a distracted sub-editor on a deadline. [PAUSE]

[SLOW DOWN] That is why accuracy is the // first priority // of advanced editing. Not speed. Not style. [beat] // Accuracy //.

[EDITOR'S EYE --- recurring segment]
[~60 seconds]

// Editor's Eye //. [PAUSE]

A story about a government education policy contains this sentence:
"According to reports, the policy has already improved student performance
in 50 countries." [PAUSE]

You are the editor. Flag every problem before I do. [beat] Run through it.
[PAUSE]

First: "According to reports" --- which reports? Who published them? When? On
what data? This is unattributed. It proves nothing. [beat] Flag it.

Second: "50 countries" --- this is a national government policy. How exactly
has it reached 50 countries? [beat] Extraordinary claims require extraordinary
evidence. [beat] Flag it.

Third: "already improved" --- what is the evidence of improvement? What metric?
What baseline? Without that, the word "improved" is an empty assertion. [beat]
Flag it. [PAUSE]

[SLOW DOWN] Three editorial problems in one sentence. None of them grammar
issues. All three of them credibility crises waiting to happen. [PAUSE]

This is what editorial judgment looks like in practice. Not red pens.
// Judgment //.

SEGMENT THREE: CORE TEACHING --- PART 2
"Fact-Checking Techniques: How to Verify Before You Publish" [5-6 minutes]

So how do you actually fact-check? [PAUSE] Here are five techniques every
editor must build into their workflow. [ENERGETIC]

Technique one: // Cross-check multiple sources //. Do not confirm a fact by
finding a single source that supports it. Find three. Find four. If they all
agree --- you are getting closer to reliable. If they contradict --- you have a
problem to resolve before publication. Never publish on one source alone.
[PAUSE]

Technique two: // Use official data sources //. For statistics, use government
data, academic research, established international organizations. Not social
media. Not summaries. [beat] The primary source. Go to the original document,
the original report, the original dataset. That is where your credibility is
anchored. [PAUSE]

Technique three --- and this one carries real weight in today's environment:
// treat AI with caution //. [SLOW DOWN] AI tools have training cutoffs. They
have data gaps. They can state things confidently that are no longer true,
or were never true in your specific local context. [PAUSE]

Here is a real example. At a fact-checking conference in Africa, the question
was posed to a leading AI search tool: what is the biggest library in the

world? The AI gave a confident answer --- and the answer was factually incorrect. [beat] Confident. [beat] Incorrect. [beat] That is the trap. // Confidence is not the same as accuracy. // [PAUSE]

Use AI as a starting point. A direction-finder. But your professional verification does not end with an AI response. It begins there. [PAUSE]

Technique four: // confirm quotes and attribution //. When you quote a person, you are giving your professional guarantee that those are their exact words --- or that any paraphrase is clearly labeled as such. Quote someone out of context, alter their words slightly, or remove a qualifier that changes the meaning --- and you have not just made an error. You may have defamed them. [PAUSE]

Technique five: // avoid assumptions //. This is the most common editorial failure, and the hardest one to correct by instinct. Assumption is the lowest form of knowledge. As an editor: if you do not know --- // you verify //. You do not guess. You do not assume it is probably accurate. [beat] You confirm. [PAUSE]

Common categories of fact error to watch: // wrong figures // --- especially numbers that are easy to confuse (millions vs billions, percentages, dates). // Misquoted statements // --- particularly partial quotes that alter meaning. // Incorrect names or titles // --- Dr. where there is no doctorate, Senator where they are a Representative. // Outdated information // --- facts correct six months ago but no longer true today. [PAUSE]

[SLOW DOWN] Every one of these is fixable before publication. Once published, none of them are truly undone. A correction notice signals failure. Your credibility is built slowly and lost quickly. [PAUSE]

[NEWSROOM SNAPSHOT --- Nigerian context]
[~90 seconds]

// Newsroom Snapshot //. [PAUSE]

An article arrives for editorial review. It is about Lagos State University. The article makes three claims. [PAUSE]

One: LASU has been ranked the number one university in Africa. Two: the university recently received 200 billion naira in federal funding. Three: 95% of graduates secured employment within three months of graduation. [PAUSE]

Every single claim is attributed to "according to reports" With no named source. No date. No organization. [PAUSE]

You are the editor. Before a word goes to layout --- you flag all three. [ENERGETIC]

Claim one: ranked number one in Africa. [beat] Which organization issued this ranking? When? Based on which criteria? If you cannot name it precisely, the claim cannot stand as written. Change to "among leading universities in Africa, according to [specific organization and year]" --- or remove entirely until properly sourced. [PAUSE]

Claim two: 200 billion naira in federal funding. [beat] Consider Nigeria's total national education budget. This figure is not just unsourced --- it is

economically implausible on its face. An editor who has context will recognize this immediately. Verify, correct, or remove. [PAUSE]

Claim three: 95% employed within three months. [beat] Given current unemployment figures in Nigeria, this claim requires strong, specific, verifiable evidence --- from the university's own published records, from the National Bureau of Statistics, or from a named independent body. "Students have confirmed" is not credible sourcing. [PAUSE]

[SLOW DOWN] This is the work. Identifying the most dangerous claims, flagging missing verification points, challenging vague attributions. This happens before layout. Before headline. Before publication. If it does not happen here --- these claims reach your audience as facts. [PAUSE]

And once they do --- [beat] you own them.

SEGMENT FOUR: CORE TEACHING --- PART 3
"Style, Consistency, Ambiguity, and Removing Bias" [4-5 minutes]

We have covered accuracy and fact-checking. Now the third dimension of advanced editing. [PAUSE]

// Style and consistency //. [SLOW DOWN]

Style in editing means uniformity across content --- and across time. When your publication writes "FG" in one paragraph, "Nigerian Government" in the next, and "Federal Government" in the paragraph after that --- the reader experiences inconsistency. And inconsistency reads as carelessness. Even when every fact is technically correct, the absence of a house style standard signals a disorganized editorial process. [PAUSE]

Key style elements to watch carefully. // Capitalization // --- which titles and institutions take capital letters and which do not. // Numbers and figures // --- do you write "ten" or "10"? Your house style resolves this. // Dates // --- "April 15, 2026" or "15 April 2026"? Both are correct. Neither is wrong. But pick one and apply it everywhere. // Abbreviations // --- standard English places a full stop after each letter (M.C.M.). Some organizations strip the full stops as a deliberate style choice. Know your organization's decision and apply it consistently. [PAUSE]

Now --- // ambiguity //. [SLOW DOWN]

Ambiguity is when a sentence can mean two different things, or fails to specify what it is actually claiming. Here is an example: "Students discussed issues with teachers." [PAUSE]

Read that again carefully. [beat] Who has the issues? The students? The teachers? Both? What kind of issues? About what subject? About whom? [PAUSE] As written, the sentence answers none of these. An editor must interrogate it --- and rewrite it with specificity. Replace "issues" with the actual subject. Name the context. Give the reader what they need to understand. [PAUSE]

And now --- // bias //. [ENERGETIC]

Bias in editing is when the language used in a story reveals the editor's or publication's position on the subject, rather than reporting it fairly.

Here is a biased version of a sentence: "The government // failed // again to fix education problems." [PAUSE]

The word // failed // is an editorial judgment. It is not a neutral reporting word. It announces that the writer has already decided the government is incompetent. The reader is not given the information and allowed to form their own view --- they are being told what to conclude. [PAUSE]

Here is the neutral version: "The government has // not resolved // ongoing education challenges." [PAUSE]

Same situation. Same underlying facts. But now the reader receives the information and draws the conclusion themselves. The editor has stepped back. That is called // editorial neutrality //. [PAUSE]

[SLOW DOWN] Editorial neutrality does not mean you have no views. Opinion journalism and investigative editorial work exist and serve important purposes. But in // news reporting //, the editor's job is fair witnessing. Report. Do not judge. Let the evidence speak. [PAUSE]

In practical terms: every time you choose a word that carries judgment --- a word like "failed," "accused," "refused to act," "ignored" --- you are making an editorial decision. Make it consciously. Know precisely when you are shaping meaning and when you are simply reporting it. The difference between the two is the difference between journalism and advocacy. [PAUSE]

[SYMBOL CHECK --- recurring segment]
[~45 seconds]

// Symbol Check //. [PAUSE]

Today's symbol: // stet //. [PAUSE] From the Latin meaning "let it stand." [SLOW DOWN]

When an editor marks a correction on a manuscript --- strikes through a word, for example --- and then changes their mind, they write // stet // beside the marked correction. It signals: disregard what I marked. Restore the original. [PAUSE]

In digital editing using Track Changes, rejecting a tracked change achieves exactly the same function. The word is restored to its original form. The editorial decision is reversed. [PAUSE]

But the concept matters beyond the mechanics. Knowing when to say // stet // --- knowing when to stop editing and preserve the original author's voice or precise phrasing --- is itself an act of editorial judgment. Not every marked change should be accepted. [beat] Sometimes the original was right. [PAUSE]

The full symbol set continues in Episode 5.

MICRO-ACTIVITY
[~90 seconds]

Pause here. [PAUSE] Take two minutes before continuing.

Here is your task. Read this sentence carefully:

"The government failed once again to provide important support and valuable resources to the struggling Nigerian schools that are desperately in need of help."

[PAUSE] I want you to do three things with it.

One: identify the // bias //. What judgment word or phrase gives away an editorial position? [PAUSE]

Two: identify the // ambiguity //. What is unclear, unspecified, or too vague to be useful to a reader? [PAUSE]

Three: rewrite the sentence to be // neutral, specific, and concise //. Remove the loaded language. Clarify what was ambiguous. Tighten what is wordy. [PAUSE]

There is no single correct answer here. Any version that removes the bias, specifies the meaning, and tightens the language is a valid editorial improvement. [beat] The exercise is not about finding the perfect sentence. It is about // seeing the problems // before attempting the fix. That is the discipline. [PAUSE]

Done? Let's continue.

CHECKPOINT QUESTION
[~60 seconds]

Checkpoint question for this episode. [PAUSE]

Which of the following is the // strongest indicator // that a claim in a news report may be unreliable? [PAUSE]

A --- The claim includes specific dates and named individuals
B --- The claim is supported by an official government statement
C --- The claim uses vague language such as "according to reports" without naming the source
D --- The claim appears in both the headline and the body of the article

[PAUSE] Consider what we covered on attribution. Consider what "according to reports" actually tells a reader --- which is nothing. It names no source, no date, no publication, no data methodology. [PAUSE]

The answer is // C //. [PAUSE] Vague attribution is the clearest editorial red flag. It signals that the writer either did not verify the claim or could not verify it --- and relied on vagueness to pass unnoticed. A responsible editor flags it immediately and sends the story back for proper sourcing. [PAUSE]

On Option B: an official government statement is not automatically reliable either. Official sources can be wrong, politically motivated, or outdated. But they are named, attributable, and challengeable --- which is a higher standard than "according to reports." That is why B is not the weakest option here.

If you got this right --- well done. If you chose A or D --- re-listen to the fact-checking techniques section of this episode before your next practical.

RECAP
[~60 seconds]

Three things to take from this episode. [PAUSE]

[SLOW DOWN] One: Advanced editing is not about grammar. It is about accuracy, truth, and fairness. A grammatically correct sentence can be factually wrong, dangerously biased, or so ambiguous it communicates nothing clearly. Editorial judgment is not just about what is broken --- it is about what is // true and defensible //.

Two: Fact-checking is not optional. Cross-check sources. Use primary and official data. Confirm quotes precisely. Treat AI as a starting point, not a final authority. Avoid assumptions. [beat] Your credibility is the sum of your fact-checking decisions. Every published error costs more than you expect.

Three: Style consistency, eliminating ambiguity, and removing bias are not cosmetic improvements. They are the editorial standards that define whether your publication can be // trusted //. An editor who maintains these standards protects the audience, the organization, and the profession. [PAUSE]

Editing is about grammar. But ultimately --- it is about // truth //. [PAUSE] Take that with you.

ACTION CLOSE
[~30 seconds]

Before you go. [PAUSE] Your assignment for this episode: find a recent news report from any Nigerian publication. Identify one factual claim that should be verified, one biased or loaded word or phrase, and one ambiguous statement. Write a two-sentence editorial note for each --- the kind you would send back to the reporter explaining what needs to be improved and why. [PAUSE]

Episode 5 takes us into editing symbols --- the standardized correction language that every editor must know, whether they are working with a pen, a keyboard, or both. [PAUSE]

I'll see you there.

[OUTRO MUSIC - fade in and hold]

END OF EPISODE 4 SCRIPT

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